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An Institute for Civil Services Examination

The Mauryan Empire

Significance- the political unity was achieved in India for the very first time with the foundation of the Mauryan empire

Kautilya's Arthashastra

- Written by Kautilya, a contemporary of Chandragupta Maurya, most important literary source for the history of the Maurya
- Kautilya was also called Indian Machiavelli
- The manuscript of Arthashahstra was first discovered by R. Shama Sastri in 1904
- The Arthashastra is divided into three parts-
  - The first deals with the king and his council and the department and government
  - The second with civil and criminal law
  - The third with diplomacy and war

Visakadatta's Mudrarakshasa

- Written by Visakadatta is a drama in Sanskrit which describes how Chandragupta with the assistance of Kautilya overthrew the Nandas (but written during the Gupta period)
- It also gives a picture on the socio-economic condition under the Mauryas

Megasthenes' Indica

- He was the Greek ambassador in the court of Chandragupta Maurya
- His book gives details about
  - The Mauryan administration, particularly the administration of the capital city of Pataliputra and also the military organization
  - Picture on contemporary social life

Other literatures

- The Puranas and the Buddhist literature such as Jatakas provide information on the Mauryas
- The Ceylonese Chronicles Dipavamsa and Mahavamsa throw light on the role Asoka in spreading Buddhism in Sri Lanka

Archaeological sources Edicts of Asoka

- The inscriptions of Asoka were first deciphered by James Princep in 1837
- They are written in Pali language and in some places Prakrit was used
- The Brahmi script was employed for writing
- In the northwestern India, Asokan inscriptions were found in Kharosthi Script
- Asokan inscriptions remain valuable sources for the study of Asoka and the Mauryan Empire
- There are 14 Major Rock Edicts. The major pillar edicts were erected in important cities
- There are minor Rock Edicts and minor pillar edicts
- These edicts of Asoka deal with Asoka's dhamma and also instructions given to his officials
- The XIII Rock Edicts gives details about his war with Kalinga
- The pillar edict VII gives a summary of his efforts to promote the Dhamma within his kingdom

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Political history of the Mauryas

Chandragupta Maurya (322-298 BCE)

- Founder of the Mauryan empire
- He captured Pataliputra from the last ruler of the Nanda dynasty, Dhanananda with the help of Kautilya, also known as Chanakya or Vishnugupta
- After firmly establishing his power in the Gangetic valley, he marched to the northwest and subdued the territories up to the Indus
- Then he moved to central India and occupied the region north of Narmada river
- In 305 BCE, he marched against Alexander's General Selukas Niketar, who was controlling northwestern India. He defeated him and a treaty was signed
- By this treaty, Selukas Niketar ceded the trans-Indus territories- namely Aria, Arakosia and Gedrosia- to the Mauryan empire
- He also gave his daughter in marriage to the Mauryan prince
- Megasthenes was sent to the Mauryan court as Greek ambassador
- Chandragupta embraced Jainism towards the end of his life. Then he went to

Shravanabelagola, near Mysore along with other Jain monks led by Bhadrabhagu and starved himself to death

Bindusara (298-273 BCE)

- Bindusara was called by the Greeks as "Amitragatha" meaning slayer of enemies
- He is said to have conquered the Deccan up to Mysore
- The Sangam Tamil literature confirms the Mauryan invasion of the far south
- Bindusara received Deimachus as ambassador from the Syrian king Antiochus I
- He supported the Ajivikas, a religious sect. Bindusara appointed his son Asoka as the governor of Ujjain

Asoka the Great (273-232 BCE)

- There is little information regarding the early life of Asoka. He acted as Governor of Ujjain and also suppressed a revolt in Taxila during his father Bindusara's reign
- There was a struggle for the throne after Bindusara's death. The Ceylonese Chronicles, Dipavamsa and Mahavamsa state that Asoka captured power after killing his ninety nine brothers including his elder brother Susima
- But according to Taranatha of Tibet, Asoka killed only six of his brothers
- The most important event of Asoka's reign- victorious war with Kalinga in 261 BCE- effects of the war were described by Asoka himself in the Rock Edict XIII
- Effect of the Kalinga war- Asoka embraced Buddhism under the influence of Buddhist monk, Upagupta

Asoka and Buddhism

- About 261 BCE, Asoka became a Sakya Upasaka (lay disciple) and two and a half years later, a Bikshu (monk)
- He visited Bodhgaya, and organized missions. He appointed special officers called Dharma Mahamatras to speed up the progress of Dhamma
- In 241 BCE, he visited the birthplace of Buddha, the Lumbini Garden, near Kapilavastu, also visited other holy places of Buddhism like Sarnath, Sravasti and Kushinagar
- He sent a mission to Sri Lanka under his son Mahendra and daughter Sanghamitra who planted there the branch of the original Bodhi tree
- Asoka convened the Third Buddhist Council at Pataliputra in 240 BCE, in order to strengthen the Sangha. It was presided over by Moggaliputta Tissa

Extent of Asoka's empire

- Northwestern frontier was already demarcated by Chandragupta Maurya
- Asoka's inscriptions mention the southernmost kingdoms- Cholas, Pandyas, Satyaputras and Keralaputras as border states. Therefore these states remained outside the Mauryan empire
- According to Rajatarangini, Kashmir was a part of the Mauryan empire
- Nepal was also within the Mauryan empire

Asoka's Dhamma

- His policy of dhamma was a still broad concept with elaboration of a way of life, signifies a general code of conduct and a set of principles to be adopted and practiced by the people at large
- His principles of Dhamma were clearly stated in his Edicts

Asoka's dhamma as mentioned in his various edicts may be summed up as follows:

- Service to father and mother, practice of ahimsa, love of truth, reverence to teachers and good treatment of relatives
- Prohibition of animal sacrifices and festive gatherings and avoiding expensive and meaningless ceremonies and rituals
- Efficient organization of administration in the direction of social welfare and maintenance of constant contact with people through the system of Dhamma Yatra
- Humane treatment of servants by masters and prisoners by government officials
- Consideration and non-violence to animals and courtesy to relations and liberality to Brahmins
- Tolerance among all the religious sects
- Conquest through Dhamma instead of through war

The concept of non-violence and other similar ideas of Asoka's Dhamma are identical with the teachings of Buddha. His dhamma is a general code of conduct. Asoka wished that dhamma spread through all social levels in the society.

Estimate of Asoka

- Asoka was "the greatest of kings" surpassing Alexander the Great and Julius Caesar and other renowned Emperors of the world
- His dhamma is so universal that it appeals to promote the welfare of humanity and the policy of non-aggression.